

5.5 Audacity

Called “the GIMP of audio” by its growing community of fanboys, Audacity is the free, open source underdog in the mean world of audio editors, which has been dominated by paid software vendors for a long time. It can edit most popular audio formats—MP3, OGG, WAV and MIDI among others, and it also has a multi-track interface that will let you mix tracks to create your own versions of songs. It’s also very easy to use, and beginners will have no trouble getting used to it.

Audacity comes with all the essential effects loaded—amplification, time and pitch alterations, etc. (read more about these effects in chapter 8), and supports the VST plugin architecture (you can read about this, too, in chapter 8), which lets you keep adding more VST effects that you can download. The Virtual Studio Technology (VST) enabler is an interface that will allow you to connect your musical audio output devices, such as a synthesizer or effects, to Audacity for recording and editing. If you have a few musical instruments or software effects, you should download the VST enabler. If you’re only looking for very basic editing, such as cutting, cropping and normalising tracks, there’s no need. We do, however, encourage you to install it to give all the cool VST effects available a try—you might just discover a new hobby in audio editing!

There’s no limit to the number or length of tracks you can load into Audacity, and it supports unlimited undos too—meaning that the only limiting factor here is how much free space you have on your hard drive. You can get Audacity from <http://audacity.sourceforge.net/>; it’s just 2.3 MB. You will also need the LAME MP3 Encoder, which, too, you can find at the same site. This encoder will let you edit and export files as MP3, and since most of us have MP3 collections, Audacity is quite lame without LAME!

We proceed to explain how to use the normalisation and amplification features in Audacity.